

The Pampas



THE PAMPAS IS A VAST GRASSY plain that covers an area of almost 300,000 sq miles (777,000 sq km) in South America. The climate in the pampas is generally dry. Although grasses flourish in these conditions, trees and

larger plants can survive only along river banks. Termite mounds, which can be up to 6 ft 6 in (2 m) high, dot the pampas plain.

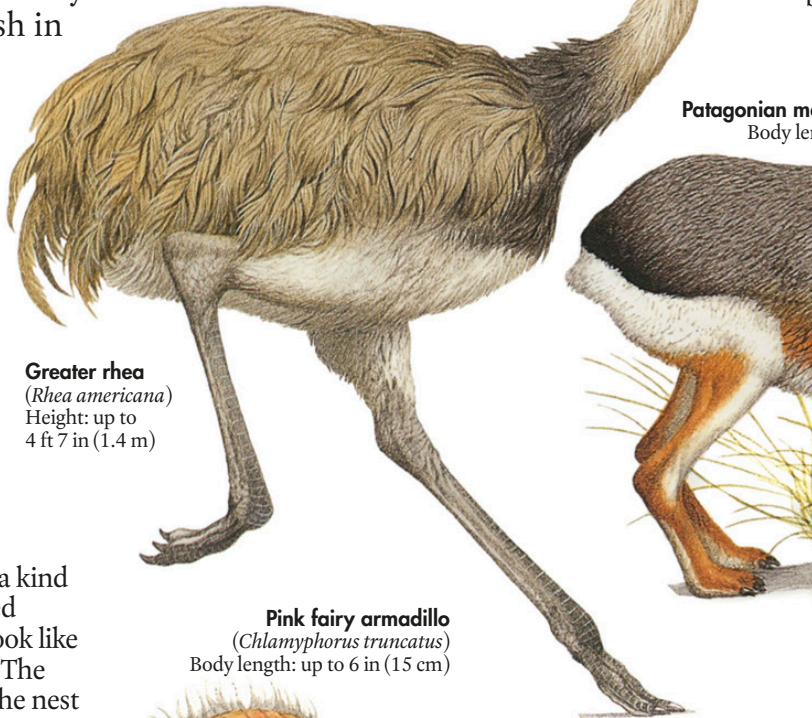
Many pampas animals, such as the armadillo, live in underground burrows. This protects them from fires, which are common on the dry grassland. Much of the pampas is now used by farmers for grazing cattle. Wild animals face extra competition for food, and some species are declining as a result.

Speedy sprinter

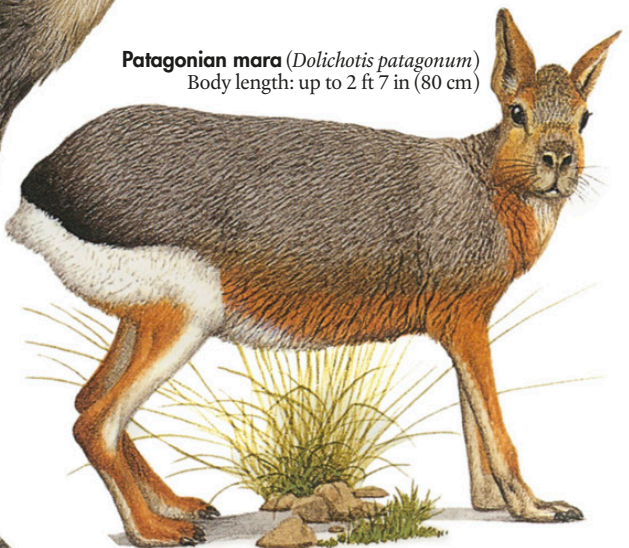
The rhea is a flightless bird. It can run at speeds of more than 30 mph (50 kph). The male rhea rears the chicks and defends the nest. He will attack anything that comes too close, even people or small airplanes.

Long jump

The mara, or Patagonian hare, has long back legs, which it uses to bound away from danger. It can cover up to 6 ft 6 in (2 m) in one leap. Although the mara looks like a hare, it is in fact related to the guinea pig. Maras live in pairs, but sometimes use communal burrows for breeding.



Greater rhea
(*Rhea americana*)
Height: up to
4 ft 7 in (1.4 m)

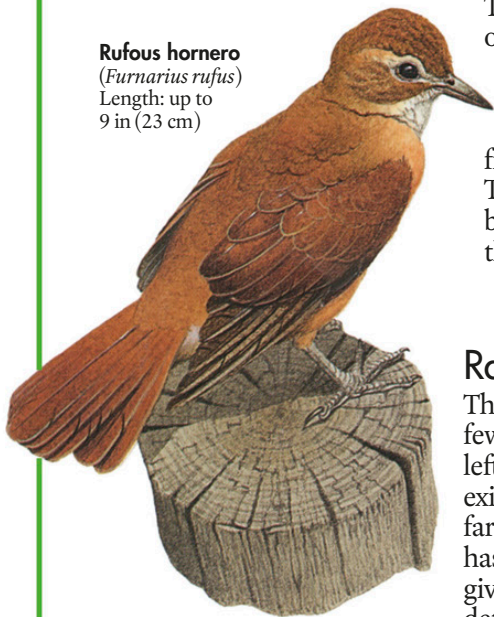


Patagonian mara (*Dolichotis patagonum*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 7 in (80 cm)

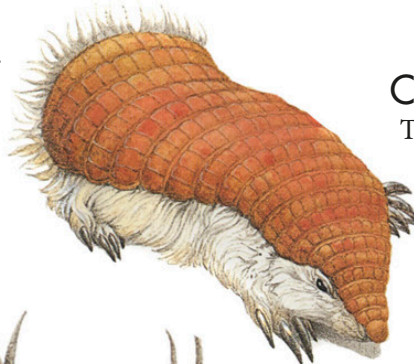
Ovenbird

The rufous hornero is a kind of ovenbird—so named because their nests look like earthenware ovens. The female bird builds the nest from up to 2,500 lumps of mud. The nest is often built on a post because there are few trees on the pampas.

Rufous hornero
(*Furnarius rufus*)
Length: up to
9 in (23 cm)



Pink fairy armadillo
(*Chlamyphorus truncatus*)
Body length: up to 6 in (15 cm)

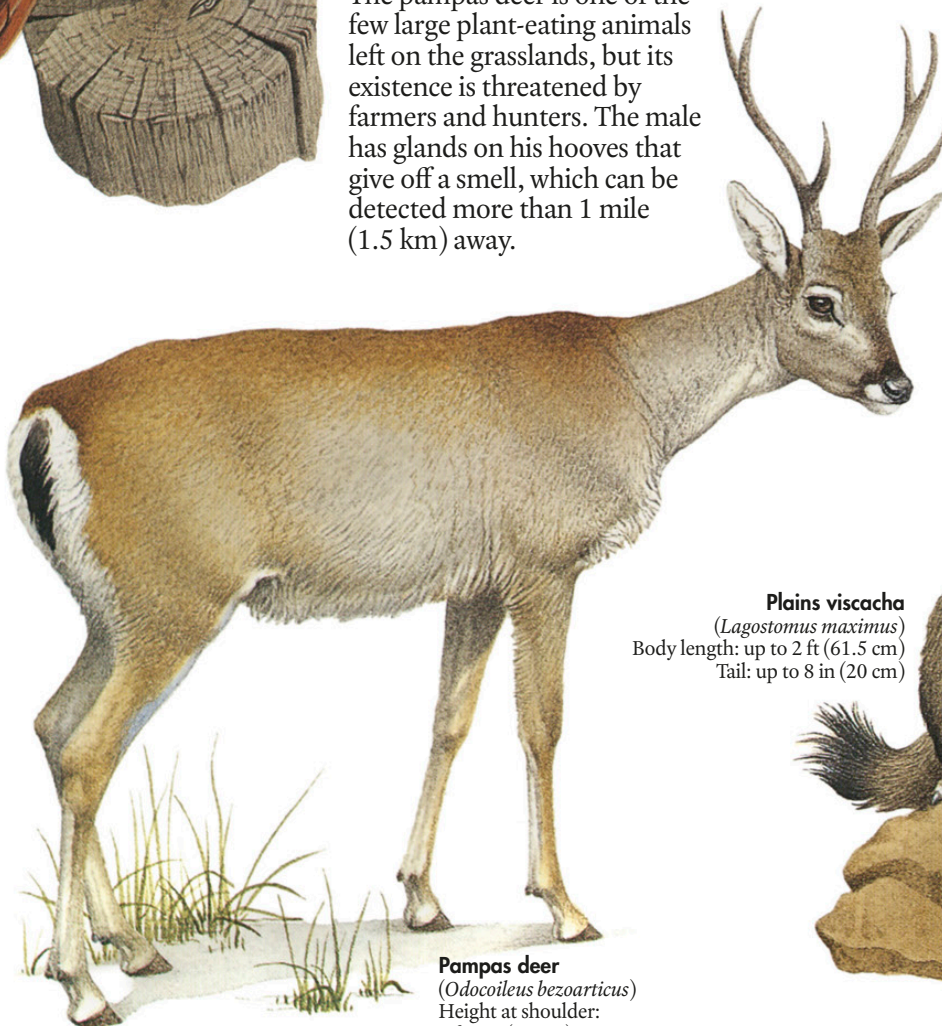


Chain mail

The pink fairy armadillo has protective armor on its back, made of plates of bone covered with horny scales. It uses the huge claws on its front feet for digging. Because it spends a lot of time underground, its eyes are tiny and its sight is poor.

Rare deer

The pampas deer is one of the few large plant-eating animals left on the grasslands, but its existence is threatened by farmers and hunters. The male has glands on his hooves that give off a smell, which can be detected more than 1 mile (1.5 km) away.



Pampas deer
(*Odocoileus bezoarticus*)
Height at shoulder:
2 ft 3 in (70 cm)

Bullying bird

The southern caracara is a bird of prey. It eats insects and other small animals, but it also likes carrion (the flesh of dead animals). The caracara sometimes pecks and bullies a vulture until it forces it to cough up some of the carrion it has just eaten.



Southern caracara (*Polyborus plancus*)
Length: up to 2 ft 1 in (64 cm)

Plains viscacha
(*Lagostomus maximus*)
Body length: up to 2 ft (61.5 cm)
Tail: up to 8 in (20 cm)



Underground city

Viscachas are rodents that dig huge networks of tunnels under the pampas. Many generations of viscachas may live in the same burrow. The viscacha digs mainly with its front feet, pushing soil out of the way with its nose. It closes its nostrils to keep soil from getting in.